

Sports Reference Guide

A Concise Overview of Major Sports, Rules, History, and Records

Test Document for Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) Systems

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1. Association Football (Soccer)

Overview

Association football, commonly known as soccer, is a team sport played between two teams of eleven players using a spherical ball. It is widely regarded as the most popular sport in the world, with an estimated 3.5 billion fans globally. The sport is governed internationally by FIFA (Fédération Internationale de Football Association), which was founded in Paris, France, in 1904.

Basic Rules

A standard football match consists of two 45-minute halves, for a total of 90 minutes of regulation play, plus stoppage time added by the referee. Teams attempt to score by getting the ball into the opposing goal, which measures 7.32 meters wide and 2.44 meters tall. Players may not deliberately touch the ball with their hands or arms, except for the designated goalkeeper within the penalty area.

The FIFA World Cup

The FIFA World Cup is the sport's premier international tournament, held every four years since 1930 (with exceptions in 1942 and 1946 due to World War II). Brazil has won the tournament a record five times, in 1958, 1962, 1970, 1994, and 2002. The 2022 World Cup was held in Qatar and was won by Argentina, who defeated France in a penalty shootout after the final finished 3-3 after extra time.

Notable Records

- Most World Cup titles: Brazil, with 5 championships.
- Top all-time World Cup goalscorer: Miroslav Klose (Germany), with 16 goals.
- Fastest goal in World Cup history: 11 seconds, scored by Hakan Sukur of Turkey in 2002.
- Most expensive transfer fee (as of 2023): Neymar's move to Paris Saint-Germain in 2017, reported at approximately 222 million euros.

2. Basketball

Overview

Basketball was invented in December 1891 by Dr. James Naismith, a Canadian physical education instructor working at a YMCA training school in Springfield, Massachusetts. The original game was played with a soccer ball and two peach baskets nailed to a gymnasium balcony. Today, basketball is played by two teams of five players each, with the objective of shooting a ball through a hoop mounted 10 feet (3.05 meters) above the court.

The National Basketball Association (NBA)

The NBA is the premier professional basketball league in North America, founded in 1946 as the Basketball Association of America before adopting its current name in 1949. A standard NBA game consists of four 12-minute quarters, for 48 minutes of total playing time. The Boston Celtics and Los Angeles Lakers share the record for the most NBA championships, each having won the title 17 times as of 2023.

Scoring System

Points in basketball are awarded based on shot distance and type. A basket scored from within the three-point line is worth two points, a basket scored from beyond the three-point line is worth three points, and a successful free throw following a foul is worth one point.

Notable Records

- All-time NBA regular season scoring leader: LeBron James, who surpassed Kareem Abdul-Jabbar's record in February 2023.
- Most points scored in a single NBA game: 100 points, by Wilt Chamberlain on March 2, 1962.
- Most NBA Most Valuable Player (MVP) awards: shared by Kareem Abdul-Jabbar and Michael Jordan/Bill Russell, with Abdul-Jabbar holding the record at 6 MVP awards.

3. Cricket

Overview

Cricket is a bat-and-ball game played between two teams of eleven players on a field with a 22-yard (20.12-meter) pitch at its center. The sport traces its origins to 16th-century England and is now especially popular in South Asia, Australia, England, and the Caribbean. Cricket is governed internationally by the International Cricket Council (ICC), founded in 1909.

Formats of the Game

Cricket is played in three main international formats. Test cricket is the longest format, played over five days. One Day International (ODI) cricket limits each team to 50 overs (300 balls) per innings. Twenty20 (T20) cricket is the shortest format, with each team facing a maximum of 20 overs, and matches typically last about three hours.

The Cricket World Cup

The ICC Men's Cricket World Cup, first held in England in 1975, is contested in the ODI format. Australia has won the tournament a record six times, most recently in 2023 when they defeated India in the final held in Ahmedabad, India.

Notable Records

- Highest individual score in Test cricket: 400 not out, by Brian Lara of the West Indies against England in 2004.
- Most Test wickets taken by a bowler: 800, by Muttiah Muralitharan of Sri Lanka.
- Most Cricket World Cup titles: Australia, with 6 championships.

4. Tennis

Overview

Tennis is a racket sport that can be played individually (singles) or between two teams of two players each (doubles). Modern lawn tennis originated in Birmingham, England, in the late 19th century, with Major Walter Clopton Wingfield patenting an early version of the game in 1874.

The Grand Slam Tournaments

Tennis features four Grand Slam tournaments each year: the Australian Open (played on hard courts), the French Open (played on clay courts at Roland Garros in Paris), Wimbledon (played on grass courts in London, and the oldest tennis tournament in the world, first held in 1877), and the US Open (played on hard courts in New York).

Notable Records

- Most men's Grand Slam singles titles: Novak Djokovic, with 24 titles as of early 2024.
- Most women's Grand Slam singles titles in the Open Era: Serena Williams, with 23 titles.
- Longest match in tennis history: an 11-hour, 5-minute contest between John Isner and Nicolas Mahut at Wimbledon in 2010, which spanned three days.

5. The Olympic Games

Overview

The modern Olympic Games are an international multi-sport event held every four years, alternating between the Summer and Winter Games every two years. The first modern Olympics took place in Athens, Greece, in 1896, revived through the efforts of French educator Pierre de Coubertin, who founded the International Olympic Committee (IOC) in 1894.

Recent Host Cities

The 2020 Summer Olympics were held in Tokyo, Japan, though postponed to 2021 due to the COVID-19 pandemic. The 2024 Summer Olympics were held in Paris, France, marking the third time Paris has hosted the Games (previously in 1900 and 1924). The 2028 Summer Olympics are scheduled to be held in Los Angeles, United States.

Notable Records

- Most Olympic gold medals won by an individual: Michael Phelps (swimming, USA), with 23 gold medals across five Olympic Games.
- Most Olympic medals overall by an individual: Michael Phelps, with 28 total medals.
- Country with the most Summer Olympic gold medals all-time: the United States.

6. American Football

Overview

American football is a team sport played between two teams of eleven players on a rectangular field with goalposts at each end. The sport evolved from rugby football and soccer during the late 19th century in the United States. The National Football League (NFL), founded in 1920, is the top professional league in the sport.

The Super Bowl

The Super Bowl is the NFL's annual championship game, first played in 1967. The New England Patriots and Pittsburgh Steelers share the record for the most Super Bowl titles, each having won six championships. The Kansas City Chiefs won Super Bowl LVIII in February 2024, defeating the San Francisco 49ers in overtime.

Notable Records

- Most career passing yards in NFL history: Tom Brady, with over 89,000 yards.
- Most Super Bowl MVP awards: Tom Brady, with 5 MVP awards.
- A standard NFL game consists of four 15-minute quarters.

7. Athletics (Track and Field)

Overview

Athletics encompasses a range of competitive sporting events, including running, jumping, and throwing disciplines. It is one of the oldest organized sports, with roots in the ancient Olympic Games held in Olympia, Greece, beginning in 776 BC. Athletics is governed internationally by World Athletics, formerly known as the International Association of Athletics Federations (IAAF).

Notable Records

- Men's 100-meter world record: 9.58 seconds, set by Usain Bolt of Jamaica in Berlin in 2009.
- Women's 100-meter world record: 10.49 seconds, set by Florence Griffith-Joyner of the United States in 1988.
- Men's marathon world record: 2 hours, 0 minutes, 35 seconds, set by Kelvin Kiptum of Kenya in Chicago in 2023.
- Usain Bolt won eight Olympic gold medals over his career, in the 100m, 200m, and 4x100m relay events at the 2008, 2012, and 2016 Games.

8. Frequently Asked Questions

Q: Who invented basketball?

A: Basketball was invented by Dr. James Naismith in December 1891 in Springfield, Massachusetts.

Q: How many players are on a soccer team on the field at once?

A: Eleven players from each team are on the field at once in association football.

Q: Which country has won the most FIFA World Cup titles?

A: Brazil has won the FIFA World Cup a record five times.

Q: How long is a standard NBA game?

A: A standard NBA game consists of four 12-minute quarters, totaling 48 minutes of playing time.

Q: Who holds the record for most Olympic gold medals?

A: Swimmer Michael Phelps of the United States holds the record with 23 Olympic gold medals.

Q: What is the men's 100-meter world record and who holds it?

A: The men's 100-meter world record is 9.58 seconds, set by Usain Bolt of Jamaica in 2009.

Q: Where were the 2024 Summer Olympics held?

A: The 2024 Summer Olympics were held in Paris, France.

Q: How many overs are in a One Day International cricket match?

A: Each team faces a maximum of 50 overs per innings in an ODI cricket match.